

RIT

Problem Statement

The Grassroots-to-Elite Gap in Indian Youth Sports — Before Khelo India/SAI, After, and Where Rit Fits

1. Executive Summary

India's youth sports ecosystem has a well-documented paradox: national programmes to identify and fund talented young athletes have expanded significantly since 2018, yet the system continues to lose the large majority of identified talent before it reaches serious competitive levels. Government data cited by the Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports indicates that only roughly 12–15% of athletes identified at the sub-junior level progress to state-level or advanced training. This is not primarily a talent-scarcity problem, nor is it primarily an infrastructure-funding problem — it is a **continuity and coaching-quality problem** that sits underneath and between the government's own assessment and funding programmes.

This document sets out the problem as it existed before recent reforms, what Khelo India, the Sports Authority of India (SAI), and newer initiatives such as KIRTI and the proposed National Coach Accreditation Board (NCAB) have since addressed, what evidence-backed gaps remain even after these programmes, and how Rit is positioned to fill that remaining gap as complementary infrastructure — not as a competitor to any government system.

2. The Problem Before Recent Reform (Pre-2018 Baseline)

Prior to the Khelo India Mission's expansion, India's grassroots sports ecosystem was characterised by a set of persistent, well-documented weaknesses:

- **Fragmented governance** — sports development responsibilities were split across 10+ central and state agencies with limited coordination (NITI Aayog governance review, 2024).
- **Underfunded and under-utilised budgets** — sports historically received well under 0.1% of the Union Budget, and independent review found under 40% of the National Sports Development Fund's 2022–23 allocation was actually utilised for athlete development, pointing to execution capacity as a bottleneck distinct from budget size.
- **No standardised talent-identification methodology** — talent spotting relied on ad-hoc observation by PE teachers and coaches of widely varying qualification, with no national coach-competency standard.
- **Severe infrastructure gaps at the school level** — only around 30% of rural schools had any playground access (UDISE+ data), and physical education time in surveyed schools averaged as little as 16 minutes per day.
- **No formal coaching accreditation system** — PE-teacher qualifications (C.P.Ed./D.P.Ed./B.P.Ed./M.P.Ed.) existed, but no unified, licensed, renewable coaching credential existed nationally, and coaching quality could not be independently verified by a parent or institution.

3. What Government Programmes Now Address (Post-2018)

Since 2018, the Khelo India Mission and related initiatives have made real, measurable progress against several of the weaknesses above:

Programme	What it addresses	Scale / evidence
Khelo India Mission & Talent ID and Development (KITD)	National school-level fitness assessment and talent-scouting pipeline; funds Khelo India Athletes (KIAs) into accredited academies.	23+ lakh children assessed via the Khelo India Mobile App; 82,000+ PE teachers trained to conduct assessments; ~266 accredited academies.
KIRTI (Khelo India Rising Talent Identification)	AI-assisted, large-scale periodic talent-scouting drives across 11 disciplines, ages 9–18.	Targeting 20 lakh assessments/year nationally; ~120 athletes/day per Talent Assessment Centre; strong early traction in Haryana (2nd-highest state by volume).
SAI Training Centres (STC) & NCOEs	Residential and non-residential training infrastructure at district/regional level.	69 STCs nationally (4,556 athletes); 26 NCOEs; dedicated Northern Regional Centre at Sonapat.
National Coach Accreditation Board (NCAB) — proposed	A unified, LTAD-based national coach licensing and registry system, replacing today's fragmented credentials.	Task force reported Dec 2025; piloting with 3–4 National Sports Federations as of mid-2026; not yet nationally live.
Haryana Sports Nursery & Scholarship Model	State-level early identification, financial support, and residential academy pathway.	1,500+ sports nurseries; monthly athlete scholarships (Rs. 1,500–2,000); 25 residential academies with diet allowance.

These programmes have collectively shifted India from having almost no standardised assessment infrastructure to having a genuine, large-scale, government-run scouting and funding system. This is real progress and should not be understated.

4. What Gaps Remain Even After These Programmes

Despite this progress, independent district-level research and the government's own review conclude that significant gaps persist — not because the above programmes failed, but because they were not designed to solve every part of the pipeline:

Gap	Evidence
The pipeline still leaks heavily after identification	Only ~12–15% of sub-junior identified athletes progress to state-level/advanced training (Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports data, 2023).
Coaches are seen as skilled, but lack tracking/feedback tools	District-level survey across Bhiwani, Hisar, and Jind (n=180, 2015): 90–93% of trainees rated coaches as skilled, but only 33–58% reported coaches consistently tracking training or giving technique feedback.
No age coverage below age 9	KIRTI's assessment window begins at age 9; the 6–9 foundational fitness/coordination stage (LTAD 'FUNdamentals') has no equivalent government assessment or development programme.
Assessment is periodic, not continuous	KIRTI operates as scheduled Talent Assessment Centre drives (~120 athletes/day); it identifies a child once, but has no mechanism to coach, track, or retain that child between assessment cycles.
No credible way for parents/schools to verify coach or programme quality	Across a 14-platform scan of existing private child-sports apps, none had independently verified outcomes; several displayed internally inconsistent marketing metrics. A 2013 Rohtak parent survey found 60% dissatisfied with talent-scheme selection-procedure fairness.
Coach credentialing remains fragmented and non-standardised	The Ministry's own Dec 2025 task force describes existing coach development as "fragmented, inconsistent, and overly dependent on individual effort"; NCAB is proposed but not yet nationally operational.

5. How Rit Fulfills the Remaining Gap

Rit is deliberately positioned as **complementary infrastructure around existing government systems**, not as a rival scouting or accreditation authority. Three specific, non-overlapping roles follow directly from the gaps identified above:

- **Covers the age band government programmes don't.** Rit's FUNdamentals stage (ages 6–9) builds the fitness, coordination, and healthy-habit foundation before a child ever reaches KIRTI's assessment window at age 9 — so a child arrives with years of longitudinal development data rather than walking in cold.
- **Provides continuity between periodic assessment cycles.** Where KIRTI scouts talent in a snapshot, Rit gives coaches an everyday, software-only tool (no hardware required) to track a specific child's development and give structured feedback — directly answering the sharpest evidence found in this research: coaches are already seen as skilled, but lack the tracking/feedback layer.
- **Trains the coaches government assessment centres themselves depend on.** KIRTI's own Talent Assessment Centres require trained sports-specific coaches and PE teachers to run assessments. Rit's coach-credentialing module — explicitly designed to be NCAB-compatible rather than a competing accreditation authority — is a direct potential training pipeline for exactly this need.
- **Gives parents and institutions a credible quality signal.** Unlike the 14 competitor platforms scanned (none independently verified), Rit's methodology uses validated, published assessment batteries (PERF-FIT, KTK3+, the OSF test) with versioned, auditable results — not proprietary unvalidated "AI scores."

Scope for the initial pilot: four sports (Athletics, Badminton, Boxing, Swimming), targeting Tier-2/2.5 geography — specifically the Haryana belt (Bhiwani, Sonapat, Panipat, Karnal, Hisar) — chosen for its existing institutional density (SAI Northern Regional Centre, National Boxing Academy, Motilal Nehru School of Sports) and demonstrated state-level model for athlete continuity.

6. Problem → Existing Solution → Remaining Gap → Rit's Role

Problem	Addressed by	Remaining gap	Rit's role
Talent goes unidentified	Khelo India App, KIRTI	Starts at age 9; periodic, not continuous	6–9 foundation layer; continuous tracking
Coaching quality unverifiable	NCTE quals, NSNIS diplomas	No unified registry; fragmented credentials	NCAB-aligned credentialing + verifiable registry
Coaches lack feedback tools	— (not addressed)	90%+ seen as skilled, but only ~40% give tracked feedback	Software-only tracking & feedback layer
Athletes lost after identification	Haryana nursery/scholarship model	Not standardised nationally; state-specific	Continuity tracker (Phase 3, planned)

This document is the problem-statement layer of Rit's documentation set. Supporting evidence, full citations, and government source documents are maintained separately in the research/ directory of the Rit documentation repository.